

WWE has been a source of entertainment for as long as we can remember. WWE games are entertaining, especially when enjoyed amongst a group of friends. The controls aren't too difficult, even beginners can pick it up easily. We had a chance to have a go at a pre-release version of the game, and we found ourselves having a good time throwing each other across the ring.

Here, we'll get right to the juicy stuff – the new features and modes coming to WWE 2K17. While this should be considered as a WWE 2K17 preview, the final game is pretty close to what we experienced.

The New Goodies

So the very first new feature we were introduced to was something we've wanted in a WWE game for a long time, the Backstage Brawl. It's exactly what it sounds like, you can duke it out backstage and anything in the environment is at your disposal. Want to throw someone headfirst into a TV? Go right ahead. There's a handful of 'OMG!' moments specifically for this mode and we'd have loved to see them all. Obviously, since this isn't an official match there's no pin count, the only way to win is by knockout. You have the option to start a brawl directly via the main menu, or even bring a 'No DQ' (No Disqualification) match backstage by just walking out of the ring!

Another cool thing you can do now is take the fight into the crowd. This isn't restricted to any specific match types but you would, of course, need to keep an eye out for the counter.

The very first match or game mode we tried was the Ladder Match and turns out that's the longest game mode. It can take FOREVER to get the briefcase but if you're reaaaally good with your timing, it might not take as long. Not that we're complaining. They've ironed out some of the issues that normally came with ladder matches in previous titles. For one thing, you won't have to struggle with the ladder being 'just a tad bit to the left' and

having to get off and move it again. In 2K17, the ladder can only be set-up in five locations; in the centre of the ring and in front of the ropes. They can also apparently be setup as bridges between the outer boundary and the ring but we didn't get to see that, unfortunately.

Another thing we noticed was matches didn't immediately end after pinfall. You could kind of hang around after the match and continue whaling on the already defeated sod. Very WWE. Bonus points!

Gameplay

While the game may not have significant upgrades in the graphics department from previous titles, they've definitely worked on the more technical gameplay aspects. You're not just spamming buttons now, you're actually wrestling. Controls feel more responsive in comparison to the previous titles.

You can now see a match rating while the match is in progress rather than after the match has ended. Taunting now plays a more key role when it comes to keeping the match rating high and getting the crowds going in your favour, which in turn means you get to use your signature move faster.

2K is attempting to deviate from the usual button-mashing playstyle to a more timing-oriented one. Timing your reversals is key. Similarly with other actions, such as attempting to push someone out of the ring during a Royal Rumble, or during grapples and pins. You still have the option to go back to the older button-mashing playstyle if you're more comfy with that, the end goal is for you to have fun after all.

They've incorporated a roll-out system into 2K17 as well, which is again, very WWE. You roll-out to safety if you take too much damage or are in a pickle. Doing so gets you some time to recover, especially useful in situations with multiple wrestlers in the ring. You decide whether to get right back in or fully recover before getting back into the action.

My Career and WWE Universe

So we didn't really try any of the 'My Career' or 'WWE Universe' modes ourselves, but if we had to describe them briefly, My Career is basically Career Mode. You can design your own wrestler and have him wrasslin' at NXT with the other newbies or maybe you could cause an upset and show up directly in the big leagues duking it out with the best of them. You've got Paul Heyman as your manager constantly telling you to do as he says or face the wrath of his best "Paul Heyman Guy."

In WWE Universe, you can actually create your own Universe with your own roster, arena, everything, just the way you want. We didn't actually get into these modes but it definitely looks like 2K wants players to have as much creative freedom as possible.

Roster

There's a massive roster of wrestlers this time around, over 135, excluding the ones you could potentially get from future add-ons and DLCs. This is the largest pool of wrestlers they've had yet, including some old time hall of famers. Speaking of hall of famers, pre-ordering WWE 2K17 will get you Goldberg too.

Graphics

There's not much of a difference from the previous title in the graphics front. However, they mentioned it would look and work significantly better on current gen consoles, still releasing on the PS3 and Xbox 360. We did see some aliasing and slight clipping here and there but this was a pre-release version of the game, so it's likely that it will be ironed out when the game actually comes out on October 11.

Verdict

Despite not looking like a significant upgrade to its predecessor in the looks department, WWE 2K17 is definitely an improvement to the overall gameplay and feel. The game was fun from the moment we picked it up. There's a ton of stuff to do and you can spend hours just behind the creative aspect of the game. *